

The decolonisation of Asia was the gradual growth of independence movements in Asia, concluding with the independence of the Democratic Republic of Timor-Leste from Indonesia in 2002. It led ultimately to the retreat of foreign powers and the creation of several nation-states in the region.

Background

The decline of Spain and Portugal in the 17th century paved the way for other European powers, namely the Netherlands, France and England. The Portuguese Empire would lose influence in all but three of its colonies, Portuguese India, Macau and Timor.

By the end of the 17th century, the Dutch had taken over much of the old Portuguese colonies, and had established a strong presence in present-day Indonesia, with colonies in Aceh, Bantam, Makassar and Jakarta. The Dutch also had trade links with Siam, Japan, China and Bengal.

The British had competed with Portuguese, Spanish and Dutch for their interests in Asia since the early 17th century and by the mid-19th century held much of India (via the British East India Company), as well as Burma, Ceylon, Malaya and Singapore. After The Indian Rebellion of 1857, Queen Victoria was declared Empress of India, thus solidifying the British rule on the subcontinent. The last British acquisition in Asia was the New Territories of Hong Kong, which was leased from the Qing emperor in 1897, expanding the British colony originally ceded in the Treaty of Nanking in 1842.

The French had little success in India following defeats against the British in the 17th century, though they held onto possessions on the east coast of India (such as Pondicherry and Mahar) until decolonisation. The French established their most lucrative and substantial colony in

Indochina in 1862 (→ French Indochina), eventually occupying the present-day areas of Vietnam, Laos and Cambodia by 1887.

Japan's first colony was the island of Taiwan, occupied in 1874 and officially ceded by the Qing emperor in 1894. Japan continued its early imperialism with the annexation of Korea in 1910.

The United States entered the region in 1898 during the Spanish–American War, taking the Philippines as its sole colony after a mock battle in the capital and the later formal acquisition of the Philippines from Spain through the 1898 Treaty of Paris.

Asian colonies from the 17th century to the end of World War II

The following list shows the colonial powers following the end of World War II in 1945, their colonial or administrative possessions and the date of decolonisation.

Individual countries

Notes

Burma

Burma was almost completely occupied by the Imperial Japanese Army during the Second World War. Many Burmese fought alongside Japan in the initial stages of the war, though the Burmese Army and most Burmese switched sides in 1945.

A transitional government sponsored by the British government was formed in the years following the Second World War, ultimately leading to Burma's independence in January 1948.

Cambodia

Following the capitulation of France and the formation of the Vichy regime, France's Indochinese possessions were given to Japan. While there was some argument that Indochina should not be returned to France, particularly from the United States, Cambodia nevertheless remained under French rule after the end of hostilities.

France had placed Norodom Sihanouk on the throne in 1941 and was hoping for a puppet monarch. They were mistaken. However, the King led the way to Cambodian independence in 1953, taking advantage of the background of the First Indochina War being fought in Vietnam.

Ceylon

Ceylon was an important base of operations for the Western Allies during the Second World War. The British gave in to popular pressure for independence and in February 1948, the country won its independence as the Dominion of Ceylon.

China

For some clarification and more detail including the sovereignty status of the Republic of China, see the following articles: [History of China](#), [Cross-Strait relations](#), [One-China policy](#) and [Political status of Taiwan](#). Hong Kong was returned to the United Kingdom following its occupation by the Japanese during the Second World War. It was controlled directly by a British governor until the expiry of the ninety-nine-year lease of the New Territories, which occurred in 1997. From that date, the territory was returned to People's Republic of China and controlled as a Special Administrative Region of the People's Republic of China.

Philippines

Philippine revolutionaries unilaterally declared independence from Spain in 1898, during the Spanish–American War, but sovereignty remained with Spain. Spain ceded the Philippines to the United States in the 1898 Treaty of Paris that concluded that war. In 1899, Philippine revolutionaries established the First Philippine Republic. Shortly thereafter, the Philippine–American War began, ending in 1901 with a U.S. victory, though isolated fighting continued for several years thereafter.

In 1902, the Philippines became a U.S. territory with the ratification of the Treaty of Paris on

April 11, 1899, later becoming a U.S. Commonwealth in 1936. It was occupied by the Japanese during the Second World War. In 1943, with Japan granting it a short-lived nominal independence. In 1944, the Allied invasion of the Philippines by combined U.S. and Filipino troops began, which resulted in Americans and Filipinos regaining full control of the nation. In 1946, the United States recognised Philippine independence in the 1946 Treaty of Manila.

Timeline

The "colonial power" and "colonial name" columns are merged when required to denote territories, where current countries are established, that have not been decolonised but achieved independence in different ways.

Soviet Union

The 9 states may be divided into the following five regional categories. The distinguishing traits of each region result from geographic and cultural factors as well as their respective historical relations with Russia. Not included in these categories are the several de facto independent states presently lacking international recognition (read below: Separatist conflicts).

British colonies, protectorates and mandates

List of European colonies in Asia

British colonies in South Asia, East Asia, And Southeast Asia:

British Burma (1824–1948, merged with India by the British from 1886 to 1937)

British Ceylon (1833-1948, now Sri Lanka)

British Hong Kong (1842–1997)

Colonial India (includes the territory of present-day India, Pakistan and Bangladesh)

Danish India (1696–1869)

Swedish Parangipettai (1733)

British India (1613–1947)

British East India Company (1757–1858)

British Raj (1858–1947)

French colonies in South and Southeast Asia:

French India (1769–1954)

French Indochina (1887–1953), including:

French Cambodia (1863–1953)

French Laos (1893–1953)

French Cochinchine, Annam and Tonkin (1862–1949, now Vietnam)

Guangzhouwan (1898–1945)

Dutch, British, Portuguese colonies and Russian territories in Asia:

Dutch India (1605–1825)

Dutch Bengal

Dutch Ceylon (1656–1796)

Portuguese Ceylon (1505–1658)

Dutch East Indies (now Indonesia) – Dutch colony from 1800 to 1949 (included Netherlands New Guinea until 1962)

Portuguese India (1510–1961)

Portuguese Macau – Portuguese colony, the first European colony in China (1557–1999)

Portuguese Timor (1702–1975, now East Timor)

Malaya (now part of Malaysia):

Portuguese Malacca (1511–1641)

Dutch Malacca (1641–1824)

British Malaya, included:

Straits Settlements (1826–1946)

Federated Malay States (1895–1946)

Unfederated Malay States (1885–1946)

Federation of Malaya (under British rule, 1948–1963)

British Borneo (now part of Malaysia), including:

Labuan (1848–1946)

North Borneo (1882–1941)

Crown Colony of North Borneo (1946–1963)

Crown Colony of Sarawak (1946–1963)

Brunei

British Brunei (1888–1984) (British protectorate)

Outer Manchuria – ceded to Russian Empire through Treaty of Aigun (1858) and Treaty of Peking (1860)

Philippines:

Spanish Philippines (1565–1898, 3rd longest European colony in Asia, 333 years),

Singapore – British colony (1819–1959)

Insular Government of the Philippine Islands - U.S. colony (1902-1946)

Taiwan:

Spanish Formosa (1626–1642)

Dutch Formosa (1624–1662)

Bahrain

Portuguese Bahrain (1521–1602)

British Protectorate (1861–1971)

Iraq

Mandatory Iraq (1920–1932) (British protectorate)

Kingdom of Iraq (1932–1958)

Israel and Palestine

Mandatory Palestine (1920–1948) (British Mandate)

Jordan

Emirate of Transjordan (1921–1946) (British protectorate)

Kuwait

Sheikhdome of Kuwait (1899–1961) (British protectorate)

Lebanon and Syria

French Mandate for Syria and the Lebanon (1923–1946)

Oman

Portuguese Oman (1507–1650)

Muscat and Oman (1892–1971) (British protectorate)

Qatar

British protectorate of Qatar (1916–1971)

United Arab Emirates

Trucial States (1820–1971) (British protectorate)

Yemen

Aden Protectorate (1869–1963)

Colony of Aden (1937–1963)

Federation of South Arabia (1962–1967)

Protectorate of South Arabia (1963–1967)

Independent states

Afghanistan – founded by the Anglo-Afghan Treaty of 1919 of the United Kingdom and declared independence in 1919

Emirate of Afghanistan (1879–1919) (British protectorate)

China – independent, but within European cultures of influence which were largely limited to the colonised ports except for Manchuria.

Concessions in China

Shanghai International Settlement (1863–1941)

Shanghai French Concession (1849–1943)

Concessions in Tianjin (1860–1947)

Bhutan – in British sphere of influence

Iran – in the Russian sphere of influence in the north and British in the south

Japan – a Great power that had its own colonial empire (including Korea and Taiwan)

Mongolia – in the Russian sphere of influence and later Soviet controlled

Nepal – in British sphere of influence

Saudi Arabia - most of Saudi Arabia has always been independent, including the Sharifate of Mecca in Hejaz which was under the Ottomans but with a dual system of government shared between the Sharif and the Ottoman Wali or governor.

Thailand – the only independent state in Southeast Asia, but bordered by a British sphere of influence in the north and south and French influence in the northeast and east

Turkey – successor to the Ottoman Empire in 1923; the Ottoman Empire itself could be considered a colonial empire

Asian colonies from the 17th century to the end of the Second World War (Japanese)

The following list shows the colonial powers following the end of World War II in 1945, their colonial or administrative possessions and the date of decolonisation.

Japan:

Manchuria (Manchukuo), Northern China (1945/1946)

Philippines (1945/1946)

Burma (1945/1948)

North Korea (1945/1948)

South Korea (1945/1948)

Taiwan (1945/1949)

Malaysia

Singapore (1965)

Taiwan (1945)

Indonesia (1945/1949)

Netherlands New Guinea (1962)

Disclaimer: Not all areas were considered part of Imperial Japan but rather part of puppet states & sphere of influence, allies, included separately for demographic purposes. Sources:

POPULSTAT Asia Oceania

Other occupied World War 2 islands:

Andaman Islands (India) – 29 March 1942 – 9 October 1945

Christmas Island (Australia) – March 1942 – October 1945

Areas attacked but not conquered

Kohima and Manipur (India)

Dornod (Khalkhin Gol, Mongolia)

Midway Atoll (United States)

Raided without immediate intent of occupation

Air raids

Pearl Harbor (Hawaii, United States)

Colombo and Trincomalee (Sri Lanka)

Air raids on Australia, including:

Broome (Western Australia, Australia)

Darwin (Northern Territory, Australia)

Townsville (Queensland, Australia)

Dutch Harbor (Alaska, United States)

Lookout Air Raids (Oregon, United States)

Naval bombardment by submarine

British Columbia (Canada)

Santa Barbara (California, United States)

Fort Stevens (Oregon, United States)

Newcastle (New South Wales, Australia)

Gregory (Western Australia, Australia)

Midget sub attack

Sydney (New South Wales, Australia)

Diego Suarez (Madagascar)

Asia Territorial evolution of the British Empire

Territorial evolution of the French Empire in Asia

French Indochina

French Indochinese Union (1887–1954)

Laos (protectorate) (1893–1953)

Cambodia (protectorate) (1863–1953)

Vietnam

Cochinchina (Southern Vietnam) (1858–1949)

Annam (protectorate) (Central Vietnam) (1883–1949)

Tonkin (protectorate) (Northern Vietnam) (1884–1949)

State of Vietnam (1949–1954)

Democratic Republic of Vietnam

Spratly Islands (1933–1939)

Paracel Islands (1933–1939)

Some territories on the eastern of Thailand. Thailand has lost 3 territories in total in the past 15 years, for example:

Chanthaburi Province (1893–1905)

Trat Province (1904–1907)

Dan Sai District (in the area of the Loei Province: 1903–1907)

India and Sri Lanka

French India

French Establishments of India, composed of Pondichéry (1765–1954); Karikal (1725–1954); Mahé (1721–1954) Yanaon (1723–1954); Chandernagor (1673–1952)

Taiwan

The city/port of Keelung (1884–1885)

Pescadores Islands (1885)

Basilan (1845)

China

The territory of Kouang-Tchéou-Wan (a dependency of French Indochina) (1898–1945)

The foreign concessions: French Concession of Shanghai (1849–1946), Tianjin (1860–1946) and Hankou (1898–1946)

The spheres of French influence officially recognised by China in the provinces of Yunnan, Guangxi, Hainan, Guangdong

Shamian Island (1859–1949) (a fifth of the island)

Palestine

Syria or French Syria (1920–1946) (French Mandate of Syria)

Alawite State (1920–1936)

State of Aleppo (1920–1924)

State of Jabal Druze (1921–1936)

State of Damascus (1920–1924)

Sanjak of Alexandretta (now part of Turkey)

State of Greater Lebanon (now it is Lebanon) (1920–1946)

Lebanon or French Lebanon (1920–1946) (French Mandate of Lebanon)

Mount Lebanon (An international protocol fixes the autonomy of the mount Lebanon under the protection of France.)

Yemen

Cheikh Saïd (Some French atlases and history books claimed the territory was French, but France never occupied it and never claimed jurisdiction or sovereignty over the territory, which therefore was never French, remaining under Turkish, then Yemen's control.)

See also

United Nations list of non-self-governing territories

Dependent territory

List of predecessors of sovereign states in Asia

Cold War in Asia

Persian Gulf Residency

Western imperialism in Asia

Taiwan under Japanese rule

Decolonisation

Wars of national liberation

Notes

References

Further reading

Panikkar, K. M. (1953) *Asia and Western Dominance, 1498–1945*, London: G. Allen and Unwin.